

TUNA'S LEGACY AS A CHALLENGE TO COMMUNICATION SCHOLARSHIP: AN EMBODY OF WORK

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I always wondered why Tuna never wanted to attend conferences and why he very seldom published anything in an academic journal. When I was first starting graduate education, I searched for things he had written, finding next to nothing. Then, in my last year of Masters work, *Contemporary Argumentation & Debate* published a retrospective issue on his seminal essay on gaming theory in debate (Snider, 1984), where he responded to each of the essays in the issue directly, taking them on in his typical, direct style (McGee, 2003). But this was not that different from something that he would write on an email list, or something that he would post on his blog. I remember asking him a few years ago if he wanted to get together with me at the National Communication Association's annual convention. "I am not going; I have a job to do," was his gruff response. I knew he was referring to the International Debate Academy in Slovenia. I wondered quite a bit if this was a criticism of the conference not being work, or perhaps a way of indicating the hard work it took to set up and run an international debate workshop.

At the time, I was enamored with the idea of a life of scholarship, which to me meant living with and within the peer-reviewed journals of the National Communication Association. Tuna's attitude offered an alternative to this dream, something I did not pick up on until much later. With his passing, I think it's fitting to tease out this attitude as a legitimate, theoretical

alternative approach to doing communication scholarship. Tuna challenged our traditional notion of scholarship with his own “body of work.” Quite literally, Tuna embodied a notion of scholarly work that involved physical presence in spaces reserved for debate performances of many different kinds. Tuna offers us a notion of scholarship that is a form of engagement that heavily involves teaching, but without the institutional trappings of teaching that we too frequently, and mistakenly identify with the act itself. His global workshops, events, and broadcasts are a challenge to the traditional notion of rhetorical scholarship. Scholarship for Tuna is present, engaged, embodied, critical, oral, and active. In this short essay, I want to examine what model of scholarship Tuna left us as a legacy.

Engaged Scholarship

Tuna’s legacy is best understood as a form of engaged scholarship. Engaged scholarship is defined as, “an orientation to community interests, as well as a way of interacting with communities that goes beyond the one-way dissemination of knowledge” (Kajner, 2013, p. 10). Engaged scholarship is an alternative to the traditional mode of university experience for students, preferring community-based education to one where knowledge is distributed from experts to those who are students. “Engaged scholarship calls for an epistemology that challenges traditional notions of scholarly expertise, knowledge as objective, and knowledge as decontextualized. Thus, the scholarship of engagement requires an epistemology that enables going beyond the ‘expert’ model to one of ‘collaboration’” (Kajner, 2013, p. 14). Tuna exemplified this not through an easily recognizable model of engaged scholarship, i.e. one that would be identified as such by the university with clear boundaries,

assessment, or within the classroom. Instead, he preferred to let debate morph into the entire process via complete takeover. His philosophy was best summed up in something he said frequently, “The answer to this problem is more debate.” Tuna here articulates a position of letting the method of engagement of students with other students over time provide not only the engagement, but the result, and the rubric of evaluation as well. Tuna believed that debate was more than a method or skill-set, but something one could inhabit; something that one could take on as an identity either socially or politically to benefit the world.

Tuna’s form of engaged scholarship was unique. I think of it as *embodied* scholarship, blurring the lines between the person and their “body” of work. His chosen rhetorical art, the collegiate debate contest, would be considered a non-starter for most interested in engaged scholarship today. With its emphasis on the competitive tournament, national championships, awards, and other such symbols, most identify contemporary debate tournaments with collegiate sport, something extraneous to serious university work. I cannot count the number of times faculty waved me away from the pursuit of debating while I was in graduate school. It is an impossible task after all. Production of an approved-journal dossier of single-authored pieces within a few years seems difficult in the light of what a debate director must do: Teach long hours, make travel plans, and then travel long hours with students to events. But Tuna believed that student presence at these events was enough to get what he wanted. Tuna’s work was the work of conversion, to get his students to love debate to the point where they internalize it; until it becomes them and they, it. But how can we understand this as scholarship? Understanding scholarship in the traditional form is

to capitulate to a rather capitalist model of scholarly activity. That is, we write for a commercially owned journal for publication, which has contours that are determined by a marketing mentality. Publishing, for Tuna, involved attention to the workshops and activities that he hosted or enabled.

Civic Scholarship

What does it mean to engage with the civic as a scholar? One understanding is that the civic involves making a difference in more than just traditional university venues, such as the classroom. “Civic engagement means working to make a difference in the civic life of our communities and developing the combination of knowledge, skills, values, and motivation to make that difference” (Ehrlich, 2000). Tuna’s legacy of endless debate workshops around the globe seem to be compelling evidence of his commitment to civic engagement. But this is far too simple to fully account for what Tuna was doing.

Tuna was an anti-institutional scholar, so anti-institutional he saw the university as little more than the starting grounds for his larger research agenda of transforming students - which to him meant anyone, from anywhere, at any point in their lives - into debaters. Being a debater was the way to live a valuable, meaningful, and rewarding civic life for him. Of course, this comes as no surprise from someone who regularly taught the works of fellow anti-institutionalist thinker, Ivan Illich.

Illich’s work is necessary to understand Tuna’s twist on civic engagement. One of Illich’s major themes is that of poverty - not the financial kind, but rather of what he called a “modernised poverty.” Illich argued that it was “the experience of frustrating affluence that occurs in people mutilated by their reliance on

the riches of industrial productivity” (Eyres, 2006, p. 140). Illich maintains that industrial society eliminates the need, and therefore the ability, for people to create for themselves. “Beyond a certain threshold, the multiplication of commodities induces impotence, the incapacity to grow food, to sing or to build” (Eyres, 2006, p. 140). Without motive, people simply lose the aptitude to do these things for themselves, leaving them lacking in the ability to gain joy from such activities. All entertainment and all needs are provided by a vast system that remains out of reach, and often, out of sight.

Tuna’s obsessive desire to build debate workshops, to sing the praises of debate, and even to provide what he saw as intellectual nourishment can be read as a response to Illich’s frame of the modern age. Tuna often spoke of the need to create people who could use words to transform the world, to make it in a better image, a better form. Perhaps his litmus test for his own work was how well he could “build the builders” - create opportunities for others to sing and build. His work in debate becomes a scholarship of poverty when seen from this point of view. The debate workshop, or large national tournament, are *places of publication* as opposed to publications-as-objects, which serve as cogs in the larger modern research university complex. Instead of considering a publication as a one-off, something worked on and done - like this essay that you are reading - a place of publication would be a dynamic, unfinished process. Thought about like this, tournaments become sites where multiple meanings are published, they circulate, they are considered, they are reconsidered, then they engender a response. Such places would be an antidote to a society, an institution, or a situation where people had been trained since early in their lives to be consumers of texts rather than

producers and co-creators of valuable texts. His work was a solution to a problem spelled out by Illich that we can safely assume Tuna was familiar with, and probably thought about a great deal.

Peer Oriented

Tuna's chosen venue for his scholarship was the intercollegiate debate tournament. Tuna regularly travelled and participated in tournaments all over the US and more recently, around the world. Tuna believed through his actions that interaction of students with other students in debate improved everyone's well-being, or even being. Students did not just become better at a subject, but became better subjects, people who were more aware of and respondent to a world that cried out for caring, human intervention. Only beings who were about more than themselves would rise to respond to such a call.

His faith in the tournament system is beyond the norm. He insisted on hosting a huge tournament, participating directly in large international tournaments, hosting the nationals of the United States Universities championship twice, and many other things. His faith in the tournament system was unsurpassed. He made no judgement on it, other than it should be big, it should be accessible, and it should be fair. He believed that those who participated in the tournament would, by virtue of participation, become debaters. The debater was the identity that he felt was most important, foundational even, to the larger political identity of his students.

Tuna's research, conference, and publication was wrapped into one in the tournament. It is not that he saw his students as his publications – instead, we should think of Tuna as a practitioner of a radical theory of authorship and scholarship, where he felt responsible

for creating venues where people could get together and compose texts that then can be evaluated, judged, discussed, praised, and decried. All of this appears in academic work, albeit more fractured, slow, and less welcoming of those who do not have familiarity with the conventions of academic prose. Tuna's alternative is a serious challenge to the dominant model, one worth considering. Divorcing the academic conference model from both university students and the public, then splitting it again for the academic publishing industry removes academic text from its organic, situational, and living contexts of its development. The intercollegiate debate tournament places all these connections front and center, quickly and repetitively, as any exhausted collegiate debater or instructor can attest.

Tuna's model of radical co-publishing was invitational as well as transformative. The results were not for the public per se, but for the debaters - he hoped they would become active, politically engaged members of their various communities, using the experience of crafting texts together with peers in debate rounds as both template and proof that they could do it elsewhere. The intercollegiate tournament model preceded Tuna, and it will be around in the far future, but rare will be the perspective of seeing an intercollegiate debating tournament as a site for such egalitarian, open, scholarly engagement between many voices. Tuna's relationship to the tournament was one that he curated – refusing to attend tournaments that he believed did not engender an environment that could be a site of publication. Many tournaments, and participants in tournaments, assume the tournament is a machine that is designed to refine and identify the best debaters at the competition. Tuna's vision was different – the tournament was a site where everyone was encouraged and required to speak, to

share opinions and ideas, and through that, we all became better – we all wound up better than we were at the start of the competition. Tuna was certain of the improvement, but uncertain of the form of that improvement among debaters. Contrasted to the traditional model of the tournament, where people get better at debating so they can win again and again, Tuna's view of improvement had no restriction. The tournament is not a conclusion, but an introduction. A tournament as a radical site of invention and development of ideas was what he wanted.

Conclusion

Tuna has sometimes been described as a “debate evangelist,” which does not do his work justice. Part of it fits: He had great faith in his work, and he believed that everyone should be involved in debating at some point in their lives. He believed that faith in debate would not only provide the answer to global issues, it was *the* answer. So, in this sense, we can describe his legacy as a deep, abiding faith in a way of doing and being. But what's missing is that portion of his work that requires “work” - his distinction between the National Communication Association and the International Debate Academy Slovenia must be one of comparison: There are active and passive scholars, and I'm an active one. But this read is also too quick, too simple. Perhaps what Tuna left us with is a choice: we can engage in a body of work that is active, that is engaged, that requires our body to be present with other bodies in order to be a body politic, an assemblage of beings performing out of faith. Or we could bend everything back toward the institutional measures that surround us.

Tuna's legacy as an embodied scholar who challenges the notion of what a “body of work” looks

like, sounds like, feels like, is his most enduring legacy to us. Tuna's dismissal of the return to the institutional norms for scholarship and publication, preferring instead his own “public” cation - the “tunaverse” as we called it on my podcast - is a critical response to the world where scholarship is not present, not active, not embodied, and not living on continuously through its own method, again and again.¹

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1 “In the Bin” Podcast on International Debating, available at <http://sophist.nyc/inthebin>

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